A Particular Woman

CHAPTER 16

Supplemental Dialog for the Beginner Workbook

by Peter Mangiaracina

Ben and Laura, two young adults, have just met at a friend's party. They stand a little apart from the other guests, holding drinks. Ben would like to ask Laura out. She is not easily persuaded.

BEN

Have you ever been to the City Museum?

LAURA

Yes. I've already been there twice.

BEN

They've just opened a new exhibition. We could go on Saturday.

LAURA

What kind of exhibition?

BEN

The history of the city. Where famous people were born, where they grew up, where they died–

(Laura makes a sour face.)

LAURA

You certainly know how to make a date sound exciting.

BEN

I haven't asked you out yet.

LAURA

You've been trying for quite a while.

(Ben smiles hopefully.)

BEN

Is it working?

LAURA

Not yet.

BEN

Don't you enjoy visiting museums?

LAURA

Sometimes. But I'd rather do something different on a date. My father took us to museums every weekend when we were children.

BEN

Did you enjoy them?

LAURA

He made us read every sign. Then he asked us questions in the car.

BEN

What happened if you didn't know the answers?

LAURA

He made us go back the next weekend.

BEN

That's terrible.

LAURA

He enjoyed it.

(Ben considers another approach. Laura takes a sip of her drink.)

BEN

All right. No museums. How about a concert?

LAURA

That sounds better. What kind of music do you like?

BEN

Jazz.

(Laura lowers her glass and shakes her head.)

LAURA

I've never enjoyed jazz.

BEN

Never?

LAURA

My last boyfriend played the saxophone.

BEN

Was he good?

LAURA

The neighbors moved.

(Ben looks away for a moment, then turns back to her.)

BEN

Let me guess. You'd rather see a play.

LAURA

Actually, yes. Have you seen The Perfect Husband yet?

BEN

No. Is it a comedy?

LAURA

I hope so. I don't think it's a documentary.

(Ben laughs. Laura smiles for the first time.)

BEN

We could see it on Saturday.

LAURA

Do you enjoy going to the theater?

BEN

I do. My mother worked at a theater when I was growing up. She sometimes let me watch the shows from the back.

LAURA

Really? What did she do?

BEN

She sold tickets. She never let me sit in the expensive seats.

LAURA

Sensible woman.

BEN

So, a play on Saturday, and maybe a coffee afterward?

(Laura considers him for a moment.)

LAURA

Yes. I'd enjoy that.

BEN

Excellent. I'll get the tickets.

(Laura raises a finger to stop him.)

LAURA

Wait. You haven't asked me out yet.

(Ben straightens up and gives her his full attention.)

BEN

Laura, would you like to go out with me on Saturday?

LAURA

Yes, Ben. I would.

BEN

That only took a little while.

LAURA

Quite a while. And let me choose the seats.

BEN

Why?

LAURA

If you start quizzing me about the play like my father did at the museum, I want to sit in the back so I can leave without disturbing the actors.

(They both laugh. Laura gestures towards the two empty chairs, and Ben follows her.)